

ASTEROIDS: DESTROYERS THEN, SAVIOURS NOW?

Asteroids have had an identity crisis and we look at where they stand now

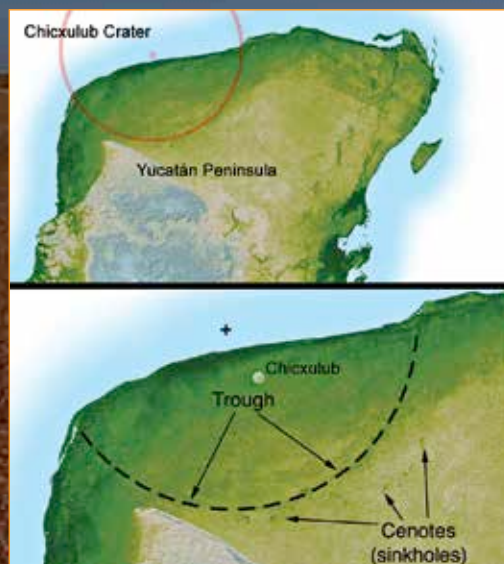
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DESTROYERS?

If you have ever had a discussion about the extinction of dinosaurs, then you would have definitely come across the theory that they were wiped out by an asteroid impact. Well, after years of being floated around in research centres and online forums, it is being officially theorised that it was not one, but two asteroids that wiped out dinosaurs from the face of the planet.

The name of the asteroid that so far has been associated with the extinction of dinosaurs is Chicxulub. The crater formed by the impact of this asteroid can be found in modern-day Mexico. The dinosaurs that have been said to be affected by the impact of this asteroid, were the ones dwelling on land and air. However, the newly discovered asteroid crater, called Nadir, is the one that is being held responsible for making the sea dwelling dinos.

The location of the crater formed by the impact is off the coast of West Africa, hundreds of metres beneath the seafloor. The radius of the impact crater has been found to be about 8.5 kilometres. Researchers who published their findings in *Science Advances*,



have claimed that if further research is able to back their hypothesis, their speculations that Chicxulub's cousin was in fact the one that wiped the non flying asteroids off the face of Earth back in the day. "The idea that [Chicxulub] had help — for want of a better phrase — would have really added insult to serious injury," says study co author Veronica Bray, a planetary scientist at the University of Arizona in Tucson as reported by ScienceNews.